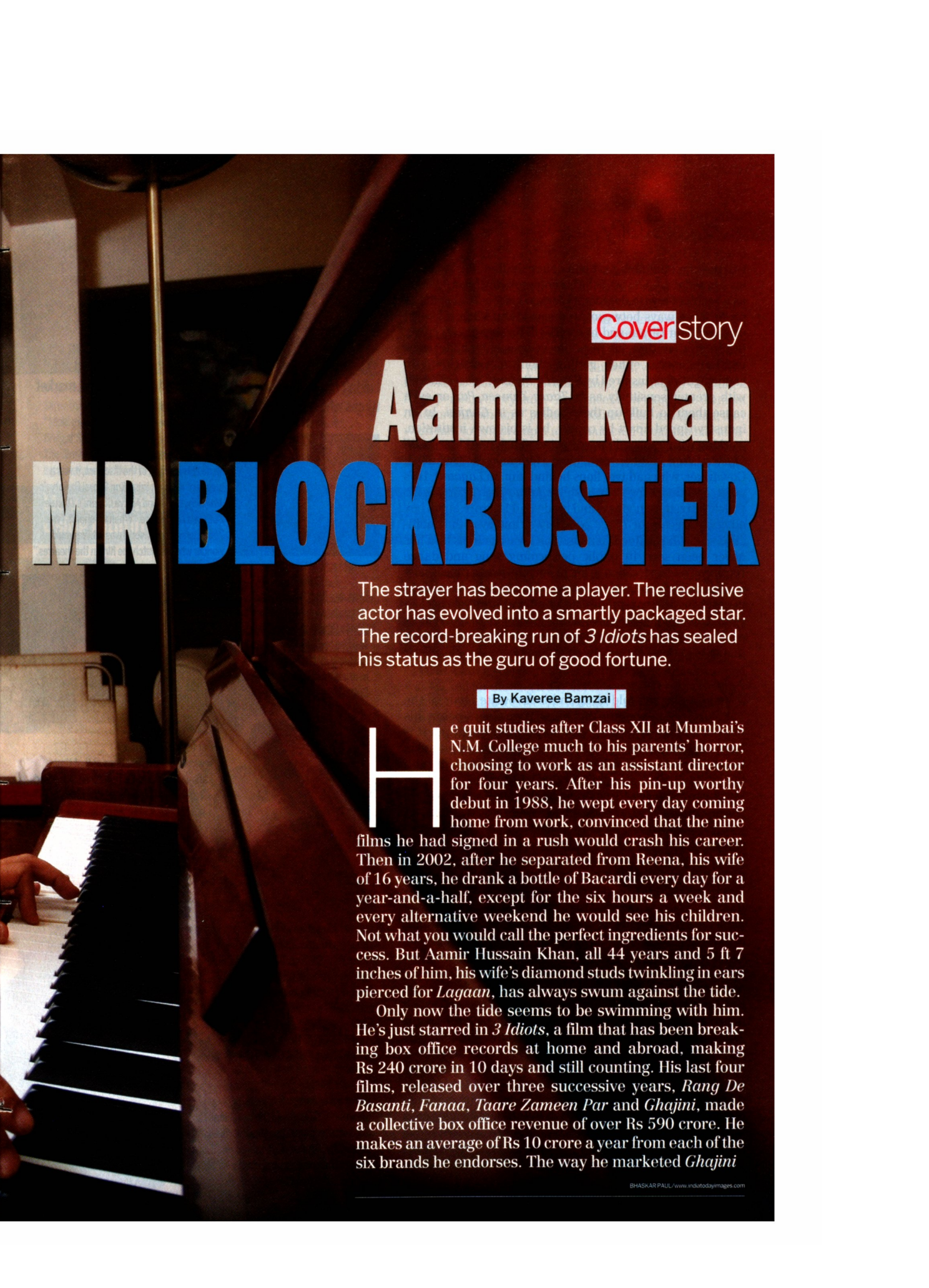




Cover story

Aamir Khan

MR BLOCKBUSTER

The strayer has become a player. The reclusive actor has evolved into a smartly packaged star. The record-breaking run of *3 Idiots* has sealed his status as the guru of good fortune.

By Kaveree Bamzai

He quit studies after Class XII at Mumbai's N.M. College much to his parents' horror, choosing to work as an assistant director for four years. After his pin-up worthy debut in 1988, he wept every day coming home from work, convinced that the nine films he had signed in a rush would crash his career. Then in 2002, after he separated from Reena, his wife of 16 years, he drank a bottle of Bacardi every day for a year-and-a-half, except for the six hours a week and every alternative weekend he would see his children. Not what you would call the perfect ingredients for success. But Aamir Hussain Khan, all 44 years and 5 ft 7 inches of him, his wife's diamond studs twinkling in ears pierced for *Lagaan*, has always swum against the tide.

Only now the tide seems to be swimming with him. He's just starred in *3 Idiots*, a film that has been breaking box office records at home and abroad, making Rs 240 crore in 10 days and still counting. His last four films, released over three successive years, *Rang De Basanti*, *Fanaa*, *Taare Zameen Par* and *Ghajini*, made a collective box office revenue of over Rs 590 crore. He makes an average of Rs 10 crore a year from each of the six brands he endorses. The way he marketed *Ghajini*